

Chapter One: The Beginning

It was a quiet morning when Ravi decided to start his journey across the country. He had packed only the essentials: a small backpack, a water bottle, and a notebook to record his thoughts along the way. The city was just beginning to wake up as he walked toward the train station, the streets still damp from the previous night's rain.

As the train pulled out of the station, Ravi watched the buildings blur into fields, then hills, then open sky. He thought about all the reasons he had for leaving - the job that no longer excited him, the routine that had become suffocating, and the quiet feeling that there was something more out there waiting to be discovered. He did not know exactly what he was looking for, only that he needed to look.

Chapter Two: New Faces

By the time the train reached the next major city, Ravi had already struck up a conversation with an elderly man sitting across from him. The man, named Suresh, had spent thirty years working on the railways and had stories about nearly every station between Delhi and Chennai. He spoke slowly, deliberately, as if each sentence had been carried a long way before reaching his mouth.

Suresh told Ravi about a small town he should visit, one that was not in any guidebook but held a market unlike any other, where spices and silk and old books were sold side by side under a single tin roof. Ravi wrote the name of the town in his notebook, underlining it twice, and decided that would be his next stop.

Chapter Three: The Market Town

The town, when Ravi finally arrived, was exactly as Suresh had described and yet somehow more vivid. The market stretched for nearly half a kilometer, a maze of stalls selling everything from hand-woven textiles to fresh produce to secondhand paperbacks stacked in uneven towers. The air smelled of turmeric and rain-soaked earth, and the sound of bargaining voices rose and fell like a tide.

Ravi spent the entire afternoon wandering without a destination, letting the market decide where he went next. He bought a small brass bell from an old woman who insisted it would bring him luck, and a paperback novel with a cracked spine that he would end up reading twice before his trip was over. For the first time in months, he felt the pull of curiosity instead of obligation, and it was, in its own small way, exactly what he had come looking for.